

Economic Development Blog

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As historic industries decline across rural North Carolina, communities are finding creative ways to rebuild local economies — without losing the character that makes them home.

From coastal aquaculture to small-town entrepreneurship to workforce partnerships, the piece profiles three distinct strategies North Carolina communities are using to revitalize struggling local economies and expand opportunity.

THREE COMMUNITIES, THREE STRATEGIES

1 Carteret County — Shellfish Aquaculture

Oyster farming has grown 500% in a decade, contributing \$31.7 million to NC's economy and reviving a century-old coastal industry.

2 Marion, NC — Growing Entrepreneurs Marion (GEM)

160 program graduates in nine years, with two-thirds of new businesses landing in Marion's once-vacant downtown district.

3 Wilkes County — Workforce Partnership

Wilkes Community College and Tyson Foods bring classes directly to employees' shifts, removing the time barrier that keeps working adults from finishing a degree.

Each strategy reflects a broader theme: sustainable economic development that strengthens communities from the inside out, rather than relying solely on outside investment to solve local challenges.

Read the full post → ncimpact.sog.unc.edu

PORTFOLIO SAMPLE — BARBARA STEELE